

Graylands Campus Project — Evidence Pack

Why local parents and residents are asking Parliament to stop the forensic expansion at Graylands

We are local parents and residents. We have taken the time to locate and read the public documents about this project. They are documents the community was never told about, even though this development affects the safety of local residents and schoolchildren, our environment, our heritage buildings, and the future of a large site in the middle of our suburb. If ordinary residents must consult their neighbours before making a change that affects them, it is fair to ask why the Government does not.

This pack sets out what those documents show, and gives the source for each point so anyone can check it. It is written by residents, in plain terms.

The short version. Graylands was declared unfit for purpose and promised for decommissioning. What is actually happening is the reverse. Stage 1 alone would take the site from about 45 forensic beds to about 85, while none of the roughly 109 general psychiatric beds have been confirmed to close. So instead of winding the campus down, the Government is on track to increase the total number of beds on the site, and to change what kind of facility it is, in an established residential suburb next to four schools. The decisions behind this have shifted repeatedly over time, have not been clearly explained, and have been made without consulting the people who live here.

We do not raise this lightly, and we do not seek to stigmatise these patients. But the reality is that they are in a high-security facility because they have committed serious, often violent offences arising from mental illness, and remain a risk to the community. Their reintegration into the community therefore carries a level of risk that cannot be dismissed. Concern about stigma should not become a reason to avoid that question, to minimise the risk, to set aside community safety, or to rule out a fair discussion about whether a better-suited site exists. Both concerns matter, and neither should be used to silence the other.

We are not opposed to proper mental health care, and we accept that forensic patients need safe, humane treatment. But that does not justify placing a larger forensic campus in a residential and school precinct without a proper public explanation, without direct consultation, and without ever showing that this site is the right place for it.

1. General psychiatric care is not the same as forensic care

- General psychiatric care is for members of the community who become unwell and need treatment through the health system — most of them voluntarily.
- Forensic mental health care is for people in the justice system, including those charged with or convicted of serious offences, or found unfit to stand trial or not criminally responsible because of mental illness.
- This project does not simply renew or reconfigure an old hospital. It changes the patient cohort, the service, the risk profile and the purpose of the site — more than tripling its forensic beds — in a residential suburb next to four schools. That distinction is the heart of this, and the community was never told it was coming.

Source: WA Health / State Forensic Mental Health Service information.

2. The nature of this facility was described in Parliament, but not communicated to the community

- On 17 May 2023, defending the Budget commitment in Parliament, the then Health Minister Amber-Jade Sanderson described the facilities in her own words as being for “prisoners who have been charged or convicted of a crime and are suffering from significant mental health issues”, and again as “inpatient facilities for prisoners and for people who have been convicted of a crime”.
- So the Government plainly understood this was a very different cohort from ordinary civil psychiatric care. It was content to say so on the floor of Parliament, yet the local community, the schools and parents next door were never told of that difference, or that it was being planned here.

Source: WA Legislative Assembly Hansard, 17 May 2023, p.2408, Question 315 (Dr K. Stratton, Member for Nedlands, to the Minister for Health; Ms A. Sanderson replied); NMHS State Forensic Mental Health Service information (“within the state’s judicial system”; “maximum secured inpatient facility”).

3. Community access is now legally required — the very thing questioned in Parliament in 2023

- In the same 2023 exchange, the Minister rejected the suggestion that these patients would be treated in the community, asking: “Is the member suggesting that we put them out in the community? Is that what was being suggested?” She described the idea of “treating prisoners and those convicted of serious crimes in the community” as reflecting “a complete lack of understanding”.
- But the Government’s own law, the Criminal Law (Mental Impairment) Act 2023, requires precisely that. It ended indefinite detention and replaced it with custody orders, leave of absence, community supervision and “safe reintegration into the community”. Rehabilitation of these patients now legally depends on supervised and then unsupervised leave. The Government’s own announcements confirm the campus will include a rehabilitation service and a community forensic mental health service.
- So the very thing the Minister rejected in 2023 is now a legal requirement of the facility being built and the community it reintegrates into will be ours. That raises a question about whether the operating model of the service, and what it means for this neighbourhood, has been fully worked through and communicated to those affected.

Source: WA Legislative Assembly Hansard, 17 May 2023, p.2408; Criminal Law (Mental Impairment) Act 2023; Mental Impairment Review Tribunal public information; NMHS State Forensic Mental Health Service (Community Supervision Orders; Community Forensic Mental Health Service).

4. This looks less like decommissioning than a net increase in beds

- Graylands was recommended for decommissioning as an outdated “Victorian era asylum model”, and the 2019–20 Budget put \$3 million toward planning that closure. The Minister herself acknowledged in Parliament that the Taskforce “highlighted the need for decommissioning and replacing services” and then, in the same breath, said it recommended “retaining and expanding” the Frankland Centre. Those are not the same thing. Retaining and expanding a facility is the opposite of decommissioning it.
- The Minister told Parliament the project would “double our forensic capacity”. The current forensic capacity is about 45 beds (Frankland and Dryandra), so on the Government’s own description this stage roughly doubles it to around 85–90 forensic beds, with a larger 136-bed endpoint assessed by Infrastructure WA that the Government has never disowned. (The exact stage figure has itself been described variously as “53 additional beds” and as “32 sub-acute plus a small child and adolescent unit”; on any of these, the site grows well beyond its current 45.)
- Meanwhile, not one of the roughly 109 general psychiatric beds (about 51 acute and 58 extended-care) has been confirmed to close. The Government’s own project page lists “increasing mental health beds” as a benefit and mentions no closures at all.
- So the likely reality after this stage is a roughly doubled forensic service plus over 100 general beds. This means more beds on the site than there are today, not fewer. This is not the closure the community was promised. It is a net expansion that reverses the original plan, sits at odds with the Sustainable Health Review that recommended decommissioning, and commits public funds to the opposite of what was announced.

Source: WA Legislative Assembly Hansard, 17 May 2023, p.2408 (“double our forensic capacity”; “decommissioning and replacing” / “retaining and expanding”); WA Health / State Forensic Mental Health Service information; Building for Tomorrow — Graylands Campus Project page (wa.gov.au); Infrastructure WA MIPA Summary Assessment Report (2023).

5. A changing plan, and shifting bed numbers, without public explanation

- For years the plan was closure. Millions were spent planning a decommissioning. Then, with no public explanation, the direction reversed to expansion, a change significant enough to affect the City’s masterplan for the suburb, yet made without informing or consulting the community.
- Even the numbers keep moving. The forensic unit began at 30 beds, grew to 45 through internal changes with no public notice, was described by the Minister in May 2023 as growing by “53 beds”, is described in current material as 32 plus 8, and was assessed by Infrastructure WA at a 136-bed

endpoint. When the basic figures shift this often, and only upward, we need to ask whether this reflects a considered long-term plan or a response to immediate bed-shortage pressures and the community is being asked to accept it with very little explanation.

Source: WA Legislative Assembly Hansard, 17 May 2023; Infrastructure WA MIPA Summary Assessment Report (2023); WA Health service information.

6. The independent adviser identified significant gaps — shortly before the project was funded

- Infrastructure WA found the business case “contains insufficient information on which to base an investment decision”, citing the rushed process, undefined scope and cost, an unresolved wastewater-plant odour buffer over much of the site, and environmental assessment that appeared not to have been done.
- The Government committed \$218.9 million about three weeks later. Either these concerns were not resolved before the decision, or they were and the evidence has never been released. Either way, neither Parliament nor the community can see that the case was made before the money was committed.
- The assessment was not made public until September 2023 after the commitment had been announced, funded and defended in Parliament.

Source: Infrastructure WA MIPA Summary Assessment Report (assessment dated March 2023; published September 2023); WA State Budget 2023–24; WA Legislative Assembly Hansard, 17 May 2023.

7. Assessed for convenience and access, but not, on the record, for community risk

- Infrastructure WA records that twenty sites were assessed “based on accessibility, central location and close proximity to public transport”, and that Graylands was chosen as best for consumers, families, carers and the specialised workforce.
- Those factors are about convenience for the service. None of them answer the obvious question: is a residential and school precinct a suitable place for a major forensic campus? No public document shows that school proximity, local streets, patient leave, supervision, emergency response or cumulative community risk were ever assessed before the site was chosen.

Source: Infrastructure WA MIPA Summary Assessment Report, site-selection discussion.

8. We cannot find a comparable facility sited like this anywhere in Australia

- We have not been able to identify any forensic facility of this scale anywhere in Australia placed in an established residential suburb, next to homes and schools, the way this is proposed. If the Government says a comparable precedent exists, it should identify it.
- The large comparable facilities elsewhere are kept apart from suburban housing and schools: the NSW Forensic Hospital sits within the Long Bay correctional complex, and Victoria’s Thomas Embling is a purpose-built hospital on an isolated former-institutional precinct. Graylands would be different — in a suburb, with four schools within about a kilometre.

Source: Justice Health NSW / Long Bay public information; Victorian Department of Health / VHBA Thomas Embling material; local school location information.

9. Absconding does occur, including during supervised leave and outings

- The risk is not just someone getting over a fence. It includes failing to return from leave and absconding during approved, supervised outings.
- In October 2025, a Thomas Embling patient absconded during a supervised community outing. That matters because it is exactly the kind of outing a campus with sub-acute and rehabilitation forensic beds is designed to provide supervised movement outside the facility as part of reintegration. If Graylands is being expanded for precisely those beds, community access is a central question, not a theoretical one.

Source: 7NEWS Melbourne, October 2025; Forensicare community leave information.

10. The law changed the operating reality after the site was chosen

- The Graylands site decision and Budget commitment predate the Criminal Law (Mental Impairment) Act 2023, which came into force on 1 September 2024. The new Act ended indefinite detention and

built a model around custody orders, leave of absence, community supervision, review and safe reintegration.

- That model may be appropriate but it makes the local setting far more important, because reintegration now happens, by law, in the surrounding community. The public record shows no sign that the Graylands plans, or the risk to this community, were reassessed after the law changed.

Source: Criminal Law (Mental Impairment) Act 2023; Office of the Chief Psychiatrist commencement notice; Mental Impairment Review Tribunal public material.

11. The environmental referral gives inconsistent answers about staged development

- The Commonwealth environmental referral describes the action as “the Graylands Reconfiguration Program (GRP) Stage 1 development and the relocation of the Claremont Therapeutic Riding Centre”, plainly Stage 1 of a larger program. Yet asked directly whether the action is “part of a staged development or related to other actions”, it answers “No”.
- A project whose own name is “Stage 1”, declaring it is not part of a staged development, does not add up. That question exists so the full, cumulative impact of a big multi-stage project is assessed as a whole and not broken into small pieces that each look minor. Answering “No” means only this slice is assessed: about 1.19 hectares of black cockatoo habitat and up to 73 potential nesting trees, not the full forensic campus this is Stage 1 of.

Source: Commonwealth EPBC Referral No. 2025/10271, sections 1.2.1 and 1.2.2.

12. Heritage, environmental and planning approvals remain outstanding

- The referral confirms the permanent removal of black cockatoo foraging habitat and potential nesting trees. Graylands is a State Registered Heritage Place, and the referral says a Heritage Impact Statement may be required later, and that development applications are still needed through the City of Nedlands and/or the WA Planning Commission.
- A funding announcement is not the same as completed planning, heritage and environmental scrutiny. Here the money came first, and the scrutiny is still outstanding.

Source: Commonwealth EPBC Referral No. 2025/10271; WA Heritage Register; approval pathway noted in the referral.

13. Four schools nearby, and no direct consultation with residents or parents

- Four schools sit within about a kilometre: John XXIII College, Mount Claremont Primary School, Moerlina School and Quintilian School. For local parents this is not an abstract planning matter — it is the school run, the sports oval, weekend sport, the local shops, and children walking, riding and playing on the very streets beside the proposed forensic campus.
- The referral records only that the City of Nedlands was “advised” of the project, with no comment received and appears to treat that as consultation. It records no direct consultation with residents, principals, P&Cs, school boards or parents. Being “advised” is not being consulted.

Source: Commonwealth EPBC Referral No. 2025/10271; school location and enrolment information.

14. What we are asking Parliament to do

- Stop the proposed forensic expansion at Graylands in Mount Claremont.
- Refer the Graylands Campus Project to the Legislative Council Standing Committee on Environment and Public Affairs for inquiry.
- Allow no further irreversible works while the matter is before Parliament.
- Require the Government to identify and properly assess alternative sites for expanded forensic capacity.
- Require a separate, credible, funded plan for the existing general psychiatric beds so the community can see whether the site is genuinely being reconfigured or simply enlarged.
- Require a fresh assessment under the Criminal Law (Mental Impairment) Act 2023 covering leave, supervision, reintegration, school proximity and community risk.
- Release the site-selection analysis, the business case, the Government’s response to Infrastructure WA, the heritage and environmental material, the approval pathway, the service model and leave framework, and any school and community notification arrangements.

Prepared by residents of Mount Claremont and surrounding suburbs. Every point above can be checked against the source listed. Contact: mtclaremontcommunitynetwork@gmail.com